



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 39

PENNSYLVANIA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Pennsylvania's family courts and child-welfare system.

83

PENNSYLVANIA FAMILIES ON RECORD
· 127 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 26
MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF
PARENTING TIME

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 26, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
32 OF 67

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

PENNSYLVANIA AT A GLANCE.

Across 83 Pennsylvania families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 127 83 of 83 families reported child counts	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$21,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 26 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 57.8% 32.5% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 83	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.5	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 83 of 83	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 32

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Pennsylvania families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02

THE COST OF PENNSYLVANIA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	53	\$21,000	\$49,471	\$2,621,940
Lost Wages	37	\$25,000	\$84,985	\$3,144,440
Other Court Fees	31	\$0	\$2,745	\$85,100
Therapy / Evaluations	36	\$1,100	\$3,640	\$131,025
Reunification Services	33	\$0	\$2,100	\$69,300
GAL Fees	31	\$0	\$1,942	\$60,200
Asset Loss ¹	35	\$25,000	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$72,100	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$25,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		26	2.2 yrs
Mean months lost		38	3.2 yrs
Total across all families		1,847	153.9 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · PENNSYLVANIA

Most families documenting in Pennsylvania are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		37	45%
Not provided		28	34%
Case closed: within last 2 years		9	11%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		8	10%
I am currently in an active case (progress is being made)		1	1%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		39	47%
Family Court Only		25	30%
Unknown		15	18%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		4	5%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		19	23%
3 – 5 years		15	18%
5 – 10 years		13	16%
Over 10 years		9	11%
6 months – 1 year		5	6%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		25	30%
Visitation Only		15	18%
50/50 Joint		15	18%
Children in Foster Care		7	8%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)		7	8%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Erie		5	6%
Philadelphia		4	5%
Chester		3	4%
Lebanon		3	4%
Montgomery		2	2%
Northampton		2	2%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		21	25%
Other: (Short answer)		17	20%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		10	12%
High Conflict Divorce		5	6%
Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF)		4	5%

05 PARENT VOICES — PENNSYLVANIA

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



It has ripped my son away from me and his whole family. I am a healthcare professional and have no abuse or drug history. I have custody of my other 2 children. This judge has been stripping my rights using false accusations and twisting the narrative ruling biay w my ex who has [...]

— JACQUELYN

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Illegally took my children kept stalking harassing me and degrading, false reports , my son was abused twice in foster care also with no charges , alienation , lots of discrepancies and violation of due process and a lot more

— PENNSYLVANIA PARENT · SAMANTHA

MORE VOICES FROM PENNSYLVANIA

This system destroyed both children's childhood! It caused PTSD and Anxiety in the children. It ruined trusting adults and people in power positions meant to protect them (OCY, GAL) Mentally and physically ruined my health as I am currently on SSI due to being medically disabled [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Took my babies with no due process after being sexually assaulted by partner altercation did not happen in front of kids. Investigation of find, no imminent danger presented.

— KRYSTAL

Children lost years with rebar father due to multiple false reports of sexual abuse, trauma from unnecessary physical exams and interviews. Trauma from alienation. Children now believe they are survivors of sexual abuse that never happened. PTSD for father.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has destroyed me as a person as well as making bond with my kids very hard

— ROBERT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Took advantage of my kids' mom's trauma and manipulated them into destroying our family while giving them the illusion. They are winning

— SALVATORE

Father SA'd both daughters. System has caused loss of wages though missed work, allowed for continued abuse of daughters physically, sexually, and emotionally by Father. Perpetuated post-separation and financial abuse. Judge stopped previously ordered sexual trauma eval ordered [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Took my children from me. Broke my heart everyday by not having them with me. Torn me and my children apart. The system has torn my children apart.

— ISABELLA

It has falsely accused, committed perjury over and over, all acknowledged by judge, false police reports.

— NICHOLAS

CYS took my grandchildren unlawfully. We are all stressed and some Depressed and need help.

— MARILYN

Completely destroyed my family and continues to manipulate the minds of my children

— JUSTIN

Destroyed a happy family. We were waiting for a date to adopt these kids.

— JULIA

Ripped is apart and did not take steps to reunify us as much as I met my goals they never intended to give my children back

— VICTORIA

Ripped away my 4 babies and handed them over to the child abuser/molester. Then blamed me for reacting inappropriately! Extreme fear for me and my side of the family. Could not say anything... or we would be placed in jail.

— LISA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



They have categorized my legal prescriptions as illegal drug use, removed my kids 4 times and allowed the father's to obtain sole everything with no evidence, hearing, or petition filed

— BRIANNE

They literally ripped my heart and soul right out of my body and left me with nothing inside but sheer emptiness

.....

— STACY

They killed me. To take a mother's children is to take her life.

— KRISTINA

Destroyed us they have ruined my life and my kids I can only imagine how they feel we didn't deserve this they want my children to forget that our three month old baby existed like I guess nobody's allowed to bring her up to them. They took them to the funeral without our [...]

— SAMANTHA

The system let my abuser who traumatized my kids cause chaos and strife in my life and my kids' lives. I have videos of them sobbing because he tortured them emotionally. The court protected him for being an abuser and broke my bones in front of my kids and still made them go [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I was a present father, who the corrupt system erased.

— NICHOLAS

All of the actors in our case worked together, included our court appointed lawyers. They knew what they were doing. We did not. Our family was torn apart, ripped apart and fed to the wolves of this agency with no help from anyone who knew the law. Lawyers outside of the court [...]

— MELISSA

This system has separated a healthy loving mother and her sons, ignored credible abuse, perpetuated abuse and allowed authority to be used as a weapon instead of protection. It has caused ongoing trauma, stripped the boys of their voices, and turned the pursuit of justice into a [...]

— LINDA

Has absolutely destroyed our peace and broken our family into pieces. Anyone who hears of this can't believe it happened to us!

— KAYLA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Broke it up, caused PTSD, ruined my kids future

— DOMINIQUE

Destroyed our family, our home. What was once safe and sacred now gone.

— SARAH

I have watched it destroy both me and my children's lives. It eve pushed one of my children to attempted suicide.

— CHRIS

We were legally strapped into a 10 year battle after a caseworker false testimony and even when the transcripts revealed the truth, the court refused to correct the errors.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I did what I was told by the court and quickly got my kids back

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The immense damage being inflicted upon a child through injustice is EVIL.

— MICHELE

My daughter & I still have PTSD from this experience. I couldn't afford the lawyer who wanted to sue the school and CPS for civil rights violations. The damage is permanent.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Torn my family apart and has damaged my poor son

— TAYLOR

Time is a thief and when you're robbed even of that thief, I don't even know how to explain it. I'm infuriated and disgusted.

— SAMANTHA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



A crooked judge removed my parental rights and placed my son with his father who voluntarily abandoned him from the ages of 3-7 after a criminal investigation was opened on the father. The judge had police kick in my door and sent me to prison twice for trying to protect my son.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Through illegal tactics ,false allegations and due process violations Ive lost the 2 things that made this life worth fighting for. Memories, connections and trust are gone now. My heart has been cut into a million pieces, with each piece scattered around the universe with no [...]

— ANGELA

It has utterly killed my soul I'm a shell of a human being

— AUTUMN

The system took my son, my dignity, and my voice. They manipulated a narrative that was unfounded despite working with every agency possible for interventions for my son instead.

— AMBER

the corruption of the cys system has done nothing short of traumatizing my daughter, myself, and my brother who lives with us. we have no other family anymore, all i want to do is teach my baby girl everything and just grow with her. almost 3 years of lost time that can never be [...]

— ASHLYN

I have my son back. My son's father/his parents attorney was found guilty of multiple things and lost her license to practice. The grandmother tried to do this again. After I already had sole custody. He was ripped from me that time for approx 3 weeks. She lied to the police I [...]

— HEIDI

The system refuse to protect my 11-year-old denying him a PFA from a known criminal/monster and instead of helping me protect my son they helped protect my family's abuser all for financial gain

— BREANNE

53 Pennsylvania parents submitted ranked quotes. 40 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/pa.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Pennsylvania report comes from Pennsylvania respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Pennsylvania — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 83 Pennsylvania families reporting here are not the universe of Pennsylvania families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 5 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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